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Analysis of the Literary Devices in Notes from Underground 2

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1. **Action:** The main action of the novel comprises the intermittent thoughts of the underground man. The rising action occurs when he plans to slap his friend, Zverkov. However, the falling action occurs when he gets late to the party and could not act upon his plan of slapping him.
2. **Anaphora:** The examples of anaphora are given in the below sentences,

i. I am a sick man… I am a spiteful man. I am an unattractive man. I believe my liver is diseased. (I)

ii. A poor jest, but I will not scratch it out. I wrote it thinking it would sound very witty; but now that I have seen myself that I only wanted to show off in a despicable way, I will not scratch it out on purpose! (I)
These examples show the repetitious use of "I am" and "I will not scratch it out."

3. **Allusions:** The examples of allusions from the story are given below,

i. We Russians, speaking generally, have never had those foolish transcendental "romantics"—German, and still more French—on whom nothing produces any effect. (I)

ii. They talked of the Caucasus, of the nature of true passion, of snug berths in the service, of the income of an hussar called Podharzhevsky, whom none of them knew personally, and rejoiced in the largeness of it, of the extraordinary grace and beauty of a Princess D., whom none of them had ever seen; then it came to Shakespeare's being immortal. (V)
These examples show the use of allusions such as German, romantics, Caucasus, and Shakespeare.

4. **Antagonist:** As there is no other person who could make life difficult for the underground man, he himself is the antagonist as well as the protagonist of the novel.
5. **Apostrophe:** The examples of apostrophes are given in the sentences below,
i. Merciful Heavens! but what do I care for the laws of nature and arithmetic, when, for some reason I dislike those laws and the fact that twice two makes four? (III)
ii. Oh, absurdity of absurdities! How much better it is to understand it all, to recognise it all, all the impossibilities and the stone wall. (III)
Both of these examples show the narrator calling abstract ideas for assistance or help. 6 . **Conflict:** The novel shows the internal conflict. The conflict is going in the mind of the underground man about his inactive state and his ruminations about his passivity and his condition. 7 . **Characters:** The novel, Notes from Underground, shows only static characters such as the underground man, Zverkov, his other friends and Liza.
6. **Climax:** The climax in the novel occurs when Liza appears at his door and makes him regret over his invitation to her.
7. **Hyperbole:** The examples of hyperboles are given in the below sentences,
i. But it is just in that cold, abominable half despair, half belief, in that conscious burying oneself alive for grief in the underworld for forty years, in that acutely recognised and yet partly doubtful hopelessness of one's position, in that hell of unsatisfied desires turned inward, in that fever of oscillations, of resolutions determined for ever and repented of again a minute later—that the savour of that strange enjoyment of which I have spoken lies. (III)
ii. You look into it, the object flies off into air, your reasons evaporate, the criminal is not to be found, the wrong becomes not a wrong but a phantom, something like the toothache, for which no one is to blame, and consequently there is only the same outlet left again—that is, to beat the wall as hard as you can. (VI)
The above examples exaggerate things as a person cannot stay in this position for such a long time, nor could there be a hell of desire, or the object flies or reasons evaporates. All these are hyperboles used in the novel.

8. **Imagery:** The below sentences are examples of imagery,
   i. I was inwardly conscious with shame that I was not only not a spiteful but not even an embittered man, that I was simply scaring sparrows at random and amusing myself by it. I might foam at the mouth, but bring me a doll to play with, give me a cup of tea with sugar in it, and maybe I should be appeased. I might even be genuinely touched, though probably I should grind my teeth at myself afterwards and lie awake at night with shame for months after. That was my way. (I)
   ii. At the steps was standing a solitary night sledge-driver in a rough peasant coat, powdered over with the still falling, wet, and as it were warm, snow. It was hot and steamy. The little shaggy piebald horse was also covered with snow and coughing, I remember that very well. I made a rush for the roughly made sledge; but as soon as I raised my foot to get into it, the recollection of how Simonov had just given me six roubles seemed to double me up and I tumbled into the sledge like a sack. (V)
   These two examples show images of feelings, movement, and color.

9. **Metaphor:** The below sentences are good examples of metaphors,
   i. I felt them positively swarming in me, these opposite elements. I knew that they had been swarming in me all my life and craving some outlet from me, but I would not let them, would not let them, purposely would not let them come out. (I)
   ii. I was not long in coming to myself; everything came back to my mind at once, without an effort, as though it had been in ambush to pounce upon me again. (VI)
   iii. The look in those eyes was coldly detached, sullen, as it were utterly remote; it weighed upon me. (VI)
   These examples show that several things have been compared directly in the novel such as the first shows the elements compared with bees, the second shows things like the dogs or some beast and the look as a weight.

10. **Mood:** The novel, Notes from Underground, shows very depressing mood in the beginning and becomes somewhat happy at times but again moves to sad and sorrowful tones.

11. **Motif:** Most important motifs of the novel, Notes from Underground, are snow and prostitution.

12. **Narrator:** The novel, Notes from Underground, has been narrated by the first person, who happens to be the anonymous hero of the novel.

13. **Paradox:** The examples of paradox are given in the below sentences,
   i. And, indeed, I could never endure saying, "Forgive me, Papa, I won't do it again," not because I am incapable of saying that—on the contrary, perhaps just because I have been too capable of it, and in what a way, too. (V)
   ii. Besides, a man is no example for a woman. It's a different thing. I may degrade and defile myself, but I am not anyone's slave. I come and go, and that's an end of it. I shake it off, and I am a different man. But you are a slave from the start. Yes, a slave! You give up everything, your whole freedom. (VI)
   These two examples show paradoxes as the first one shows two contradictory ideas of being capable and incapable and the second shows man and woman given in the same sentences

14. **Personification**: The examples of personifications are in the following sentences,
   i. A grim idea came into my brain and passed all over my body, as a horrible sensation, such as one feels when one goes into a damp and mouldy cellar. There was something unnatural in those two eyes, beginning to look at me only now. (VI)
   ii. You give your love to be outraged by every drunkard! Love! But that's everything, you know, it's a priceless diamond, it's a maiden's treasure, love. (VII)
   iii. But behind the bewilderment the truth was already gleaming. The loathsome truth. (VII)
   These examples show as if the idea, love, and truthfulness have life and emotions of their own.

15. **Protagonist:** The underground man himself is the protagonist of the novel. The novel starts with his reflection about him and ends almost on the same note.

16. **Repetition:** The repetitions examples are given in the below sentences,
   i. I got to the point of feeling a sort of secret abnormal, despicable enjoyment in returning home to

my corner on some disgusting Petersburg night, acutely conscious that that day I had committed a loathsome action again, that what was done could never be undone, and secretly, inwardly gnawing, gnawing at myself for it, tearing and consuming myself till at last the bitterness turned into a sort of shameful accursed sweetness, and at last—into positive real enjoyment! Yes, into enjoyment, into enjoyment! I insist upon that. I have spoken of this because I keep wanting to know for a fact whether other people feel such enjoyment? (II)

ii. It will itself be ashamed of its imaginings, but yet it will recall it all, it will go over and over every detail, it will invent unheard of things against itself, pretending that those things might happen, and will forgive nothing. (III)

Both examples show repetition of different things and ideas such as of "gnawing", "enjoyment" and "over and over."

17. **Rhetorical Questions:** The below sentences are good examples of rhetorical questions as given in the novel,

    i. But enough… Ech, I have talked a lot of nonsense, but what have I explained? How is enjoyment in this to be explained? But I will explain it. (II)

    ii. To begin to act, you know, you must first have your mind completely at ease and no trace of doubt left in it. Why, how am I, for example, to set my mind at rest? Where are the primary causes on which I am to build? Where are my foundations? Where am I to get them from? (V)

    iii. Cold shivers suddenly ran down me. Wouldn't it be better … to go straight home? My God, my God! Why did I invite myself to this dinner yesterday? (VI)

    iv. But—what for? I thought. Should I not begin to hate her, perhaps, even tomorrow, just because I had kissed her feet today? Should I give her happiness? Had I not recognised that day, for the hundredth time, what I was worth? Should I not torture her? (X)

    These examples show the use of rhetorical questions posed but different characters not to elicit answers but to stress upon the underlined idea.

18. **Setting:** The setting of the novel, Notes from Underground, is some basement of a house in the Russian town of St. Petersburg.

19. **Simile:** The below sentences are perfect examples of similes,

    i. Such a gentleman simply dashes straight for his object like an infuriated bull with its horns down, and nothing but a wall will stop him. (III)

    ii. Though in certain circumstances these gentlemen bellow their loudest like bulls, though this, let us suppose, does them the greatest credit. (III)

    iii. I should have exuded tears like a wet sponge. (VII)

    iv. All human actions will then, of course, be tabulated according to these laws, mathematically, like tables of logarithms up to 108,000, and entered in an index. (VII)

    v. It came back vividly to my mind a few days ago, and has remained haunting me like an annoying tune that one cannot get rid of. (VIII)

    These are similes as the use of the word "like" shows the comparison between different things.